

Finding Memo

A curious inversion of sorts happens when you have used a computer for a while. Discovering, or even creating new information, doesn't remain the most time consuming task. Instead, looking for already-existing information takes precedence.

You truly “use a computer” only when everything you do is augmented by its capabilities-saving notes and memos, communication, tracking tasks and activity co-ordination, i.e., when you turn to a PC to store contact details, when you have an archive of all your snail-mail correspondence as word-processor documents. This dependence increases as you being using these devices to store digital photos, making them entertainment hubs with music libraries and have video streaming to your TV.

In the digital world, it is supposedly easier to find anything you want. Evidently, it is not. It's hard enough finding new things, but searching for a piece of information you know you have, in vast amounts of data, can be exceedingly frustrating.

A small hard disk keeps things under manageable limits, because you are forced to keep a tight leash, or risk running out of space quickly. However, these days, when it is *de rigeur* to have anywhere between 40 GB to 120 GB of personal data space, where does all that data go? Beyond a point, organising your documents, e-mails, Web site links and saved pages, crosses the point of diminishing returns-you either have a fastidiously organised directory tree with hundreds of folders that are a nightmare to navigate, or it all collapses to a couple of folders creating a mess you'd rather not look at.

When businesses first had gigabytes of data to manage, they turned to database servers with specialised data processing languages to create order out of the chaos. Unfortunately, we're still stuck with slow search tools, different accounts for e-mail, and even different kinds of files. The legacy paper-based metaphors represented by the desktop with files and folders, does nothing to improve upon paper-based limitations. When a digital yellow sticky note is the epitome of accessible task management, it speaks volumes about lack of progress.

But there is hope. A quick look around research circles reveals plenty of activity, with projects such as “Keeping Found Things Found” and “Stuff I've Seen”, that are very encouraging. The primary factor holding back fast local searches, used to be lack of computing power. Now, here's where the gigahertz of idle processing power can finally be put to profitable use.



sumod_hajela@jasubhai.com



Sumod Hajela
Assistant Editor

“When a digital yellow sticky note is the epitome of accessible task management, it speaks volumes about lack of progress”